

Classical Programming Languages: The Saga of Pascal

In the first two articles in this series on classical programming languages, we have discussed Fortran and COBOL — two languages in their early sixties. In the last and final article in this series, we will discuss Pascal, a language in its early fifties and more than a decade younger than the two languages discussed earlier.



Pascal is named after Blaise Pascal, a French mathematician, physicist, philosopher and a man of many other distinctions. It is fun to know that, in addition to a programming language, the SI derived unit of pressure (Pascal), Pascal's wager, Pascal's triangle, Pascal's law, etc, are all named after Blaise Pascal. So, be sure to add sufficient keywords while searching for Pascal, for either the man or the programming language on the Internet.

Before any further discussion, we need to build a case in favour of Pascal. Fortran is still relevant because it is respected as a powerful scientific computing tool even today. COBOL is also relevant because of the millions

(if not billions) of lines of legacy code still in service in the financial sector. Why is Pascal still relevant? There are three reasons for this. First, there are many historic reasons for every programmer, even the younger ones, to know something about Pascal. Being relatively easy to learn, Pascal was regularly taught at many schools and colleges until the first decade of the 21st century. Being part of academia for more than four decades itself makes Pascal an interesting programming language. But there are many practical reasons also for having some idea about Pascal. The second reason, and a practical one for that matter, is the popularity of Object Pascal, an object-oriented enhancement of Pascal. Object Pascal is still used as a development tool by many software

companies. I am a bit sad to say that the third reason is 'proprietary' in nature. There is software called Delphi which is widely used in the industry. Delphi is an IDE for a dialect of Object Pascal, also called Delphi. It is used for rapid development of desktop and mobile applications. But Delphi is not free software. However, it operates on the freemium model, whereby the basic model is made available free of cost.

Now, let us see how Pascal/Object Pascal/Delphi fare in various programming languages ranking schemes to confirm that Pascal indeed is still relevant. The TIOBE Index is a very popular programming languages ranking scheme. It ranked Delphi/Object Pascal in the 12th position in April 2021, a jump of 10 places forward from the